

management vertical, Clout, manages about 250 creators and talent contributes more than a third of the parent company's business. Annual earnings could range from ₹20 lakh to ₹1.5 crore for macro creators while mega creators may earn well into double-digit crores.

As earnings rise and brands chase phone-first consumers, an inevitable question arises: Is content creation a viable sole income? Jha puts it bluntly, "A majority of the current youth want to be creators. They start their channels, but only a handful of them can stick to it." Turning content into meaningful brand deals takes consistency and persistence.

work on alternate weeks doing what I enjoy." This is a flexibility most traditional jobs don't offer.

The silver lining lies in a steadily levelling playing field, powered by deeper internet penetration and social media platforms rolling out creator-friendly tools and new monetisation pathways. Brands, the biggest drivers of this ecosystem, are expanding their 'creator budgets' as online exposure continues to convert into real consumer demand. Plum considers creators a part of the acquisition engine. "Creator-led content meaningfully influences our digital customer acquisition, even when it isn't the final click,"

digital collaborations via direct partnerships. "We also provide international stages for young talents through the MSI Creator Award, hosting creation contests and offering cash rewards and trips to world-class exhibitions like Adobe Max in the US," says Lin.

Looking ahead, creators are placing greater emphasis on short-form content, even as a parallel shift toward deeper storytelling formats gains traction. Shrivastava chimes in, "Reality content is going to become big on social media as younger people like raw and authentic content." She is also bullish on podcasts and micro-drama formats. "The creator," Shrivastava says, "is steadily becoming the nucleus of the media ecosystem itself." More are likely to follow in the footsteps of contentpreneurs like Kusha Kapila (UnderNeat) or Aanam C (Wearified), focusing on building their own brands.

For all the scale, capital flows and a viable professional pathway that now orbit the creator economy, the people driving it are still struggling to explain this to their families.

"My mother thinks I am acting for the brands. Indian parents believe a nine-to-six job is discipline and real work," says an amused Kavya.

Becoming a Gen Z creator ensures autonomy and income potential but it also means operating in a volatile environment of shifting attention spans. What cannot be ignored is the influence this group now exerts on culture and consumption. For now, India's Gen Z creators with their rizz are just out here stacking brand collabs, manifesting big bucks and no cap, hoping the creator economy, just like the content they create, absolutely slaps. **BT**

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Gaurang, the gamer, cautions creators against quitting their jobs too early. His income is split between platform monetisation and brand deals, but his expenses mirror a production-house budget. Krutika seconds this, as many creators often underestimate hidden costs like the time spent on planning, shooting, and editing. She adds, "As content becomes more professional, production expenses and the need for a team also increase."

With scale comes pressure. "From the day you lock a brand campaign till the day it goes live, you're under pressure. Background, outfit, hair, makeup — everything is pre-approved," says Priyam. On the flipside, she beams, "I only

says Baliga.

"Even a nano creator can easily earn ₹2,000 to ₹15,000 for a branded video or post," says Jha. Soni sees today's creators moving away from a single-format approach to building resilient businesses using a multi-format flywheel. She highlights how YouTube Shorts, with over 650 million monthly logged-in viewers in India, serves as the primary on-ramp for creators to find new audiences, while long-form video becomes a trust-building engine, where creators can develop their digital IP.

Brands, too, are increasingly helping creators not just to jumpstart their journeys but to support them as they grow. MSI maintains a 20% year-on-year growth in